inexplicably, cheaper than back home. These humorous posts became a source of national angst in 2014, when a former army intelligence officer named Naor Narkis shared a German supermarket receipt on Facebook. It listed, among other things, a cup of chocolate pudding for 19 cents, roughly three-quarters of a shekel. The Israeli equivalent, a popular dessert called Milky, costs nearly four shekels. “We challenge somebody to buy the same [items] wherever they choose in Israel,” wrote Narkis, who started the page anonymously. He asked them to list the local prices, which were higher. He called the group it *Olim l’Berlin*. (The word *olim* is a collective noun for people who have made *aliyah*.)

Thousands of people joined his Facebook group. Few of them actually decamped for Germany. But his posts prompted a furious reaction from Israel’s political class. Yair Lapid, the finance minister, called him “anti-Zionist.” The agriculture minister said he “pities the Israelis who don’t remember the Holocaust and abandon Israel for a pudding.”

Yet none of them had any solutions for the problem. Three years earlier, Israel saw its largest protests in nearly two decades, since the era of the Oslo Accords—but this time, over cottage cheese. Itzik Elrov, a young ultra-Orthodox man from Bnei Brak, came home furious after a June visit to his neighborhood grocery. He had paid 6.90 shekels (then about $2) for a nine-ounce tub of the stuff, a popular staple in Ashkenazi kitchens (Israelis spend hundreds of millions of dollars on it annually). The price had gone up roughly 40 per cent over the past five years—at a time when annual inflation was below 2 per cent. “Don’t buy it this month,” he wrote, urging Israelis to boycott the product “until it spoils on the shelves.”

For decades, the prices of cottage cheese and other dairy staples were controlled by the government, adjusted every year based on the inflation rate and the cost of raw materials. The government began to phase out the controls in 2006, part of a broader push toward deregulation, and the price quickly soared, even during a period when the price of milk dropped. “Only part of the price increase of cottage cheese after deregulation can be attributed to increases in input prices,” three scholars concluded in a 2016 study of the stuff (some academics, it seems, get all the fun assignments).[7] Elrov’s post struck a nerve: by the end of June, more than 100,000 people had joined his group calling for a boycott. Major supermarket chains, sensing an opportunity for some good PR, quickly dropped their prices.